Inquiry-Relative Categories: English Interjections as a Worked Case

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4th November 2026

Abstract

Linguistic category disputes often seek one classification for expressions that support several kinds of inference. I develop an account of inquiry-relative categories through English interjections. Several diagnostics converge on core members of the lexical category, including *ouch*, *oops*, *hey*, and *sh*. In their conventional uses these words stand alone or supplement a clause, take no dependents, don't inflect, and have non-propositional meaning. What's been observed of a member supports expectations about what hasn't: other environments, characteristic meanings and conversational uses, separate intonational packaging, and possibilities for unusual phonology. Within syntax, interjections, noun phrases, and relative clauses can share supplement function, whose prosodic expectations cross category boundaries. Expressive contribution connects standalone *Damn!* with prenominal *damn*, an integrated modifier outside the category. Comparing stance with sound depiction in *Bang!* shows why even one question about what a use contributes can require several distinctions. As with proper names and proper nouns, each classification is anchored in one kind of property and counts properties of other kinds in its cluster, which makes crosscutting classifications mutually informative. The properties used to assign a case don't confine what membership lets an investigator expect about it, and a partial association doesn't erase the differences between groupings. Several classifications can be correct without one superseding the others, while incompatible claims about the same use remain open to empirical adjudication.

Keywords: inquiry-relative categories; category pluralism; projectibility; interjections; sign-types; path dependence

AI use. The large language models Claude Opus 4.8, Claude Opus 5, Claude Opus 5.5, GPT-5.6 Sol, GPT-6 Astra Pro, and GPT-6 (Codex) served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

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1 Introduction

Standalone *Damn!*, complement-taking *Damn these mosquitoes!*, and prenominal *damn* in *the damn car* share an expressive contribution but differ in how they combine with other words. In the first, *damn* constitutes an independent utterance; in the second, it takes a noun-phrase complement; in the third, it functions as a modifier within a noun phrase. Expressive classification brings these uses together, while analyses of function, constructional status, and lexical category distinguish them and ask which belong to the category interjection.

Ouch! constitutes an utterance on its own and supplements a clause in *Ouch, that hurt*. It takes no dependents, doesn't inflect, and conveys a reaction rather than describing one. Attention-getting *hey* and silencing *sh* share most of that profile while doing different conversational jobs. Because these properties co-occur, observing some of them in a form gives reason to expect the others, and membership in the lexical category they converge on carries further expectations: separate intonational packaging, and room for sounds unusual elsewhere in English. A lexical category can guide inquiry well beyond the evidence used to assign any one of its members.

Within syntax, lexical category is one classification among several. In *Ah, so you were there after all!*, *ah* is an interjection functioning as a supplement. A noun phrase or relative clause can serve that function too. Classifying by function connects expressions that category distinguishes, with expectations of its own about their relation to an anchor and their prosodic packaging.

A comparison with depictive *Bang!* exposes a further distinction. The selected *damn* use conveys an evaluative stance; the selected *Bang!* depicts a sound. Both concern what a use contributes to interpretation, but they motivate different groupings and different questions. Calling both interjections wouldn't show that they share the relevant properties of meaning.

This paper asks what warrants recognizing a category for an inquiry. An inquiry identifies a question and a standard of success; evidence constrains which grouping answers it. A field can pursue several inquiries, an inquiry can employ several categories, and a category can serve questions pursued across fields. What establishes membership and what membership warrants expecting are distinct questions. English interjections make this many-to-many relation visible because grammars and studies of meaning, interaction, sound, and history organize the same material in overlapping but different ways.

CGEL's distinction between proper names and proper nouns shows how such categories relate. Proper names are a semantic category whose central cases are expressions "conventionally adopted as the name of a particular entity" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 515). A proper-noun head, as in *Mary* or *Melbourne*, is among their properties, though not a necessary one: *the University of Manchester* is a name headed by the common noun *university*. Proper nouns are a lexical category, the nouns "specialised to the function of heading proper names", so naming use is among their properties (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 516). The lexical category interjection and the semantic category of expressive signs are related in the same way: each is anchored in one kind of property and counts properties of the other kind in its cluster.

A grouping can make measurement comparable or description informative; the distinctions among *damn* uses have descriptive value before any new prediction is tested. Projectibility concerns the warrant for expectations beyond the evidence used to identify a case (what observing some properties licenses predicting about others; Goodman, 1955). Neither descriptive usefulness nor a successful projection supplies its own causal explanation.

Pluralism about useful and objectively grounded groupings has substantial precedents. Dupré (1993, pp. 5–7, 17–18) relates the choice of classification to the goals of inquiry while rejecting one uniquely privileged division of things. Khalidi (2013, pp. 63–64, 69–72) defends crosscutting kinds answering different epistemic interests. Their wider metaphysical commitments needn't all be adopted to recognize that distinct questions can require overlapping groupings.

Within linguistics, Haspelmath (2010, pp. 663, 666, 680) distinguishes language-particular descriptive categories from concepts designed for cross-language comparison. Here the division of labour is different, since several inquiries within English can organize the same expressions differently. English grammar writing has done so from its start. Bullokar's interjection of 1586 was anchored in meaning, any word or clause spoken with "a sudden passion of the mind", and its cluster reached into syntax and sound: such speech came "under an unperfect voice" and was "in effect unparsable" (Bullokar, 1586/1906, p. 350). Its meaning was read from the speaker's gesture and countenance, and it occurred alone or "mixt in sentence" (Bullokar, 1586/1906, p. 373). Grammars on Ramist lines filed the same forms among adverbs or among words that make no utterance on their own, and three of the six English grammars printed between 1569 and 1621 don't use the label (Bagli, 2026, pp. 483–485). The argument starts with a positive case, the lexical category interjection, and follows its relation to other groupings. Membership supports a wider profile of expectations, including reactions and attempts to direct attention or action. An expressive grouping connects members of the category with a prenominal modifier outside it. That partial alignment makes each classification informative about the others while leaving each with work to do, and specifying the bearer, grouping, and intended inference shows when two analyses compete and what evidence could decide between them.

The worked cases are named for the relations they investigate: the lexical category interjection, expressive signs, depictive signs, continuers, repair initiators, and closing formats. They needn't all operate at the same level of generality or retain an interjection label. Examples for every perspective come from interjection disputes; each perspective's own literature would supply bearers beyond them, such as epithets for expressives, onomatopoeic nouns and verbs for depiction, and *What?* or a repeat with rising intonation for repair. In the lexical comparisons and the comparisons of meaning, the bearer is a conventionalized sign-type, an identifiable expression in a conventional use. Functional classification concerns expressions in constructional relations. Classifications of realizations or historical changes introduce further bearers, connected explicitly to these sign-types. Examples are constructed unless a source is given, and the tables record analytical judgments, not annotation results.

The historical case concerns PATH DEPENDENCE: development can leave source-specific traces after uses converge. Gehweiler's history of *gee* supplies a documented explanation of one outcome; a verbal route to complement-taking *damn* remains partly reconstructive. The corpus material has a narrower role, showing how tags and strings can fail to identify the intended bearers. A linked supplement preserves the detailed measurement checks and two analyses that can't bear confirmatory weight.

Section 2 identifies core members of the lexical category and their wider profile, compares category with syntactic function, and traces expressive and depictive relations. Section 3 distinguishes the achievements of these groupings. Sections 4 and 5 apply the assessment to phonological and historical claims; Section 6 considers broader social and processing classes. The measurement case and

discussion then draw out what changes when the object, grouping, and claim are kept explicit.

2 Several classifications of signs and constructions

Grammars and studies of meaning and interaction organize the traditional interjection domain differently. Jespersen (1924, p. 90) treated interjection as a manner in which words of other categories are used. *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* (*CGEL*) recognizes a lexical category (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 22). The *Longman Grammar of Spoken and Written English* places interjections within the broader class of inserts, while assigning *damn*, *gosh*, and *gee* to expletives (Biber et al., 1999, pp. 1082–1083, 1094–1095).

The disputes concern a well-studied domain. Libert (2019) questions the description of interjections as neglected; Cram (2008, p. 63) identifies their recurring role in controversies over the syntax–pragmatics and semantics–pragmatics boundaries. The following comparisons preserve what those traditions distinguish without treating each tradition as the source of exactly one category.

2.1 The lexical category and what membership projects

Someone drops a cup and says *Oops!*; someone catches a finger in a drawer and says *Ouch!*. Either reaction can also accompany a clause. The following pairs illustrate the two environments.

(1) a. *Oops!* *Oops, I've dropped it!*
b. *Ouch!* *Ouch, that hurt!*

In the independent utterances, the lexical item supplies the expression without an unspoken clause. In the longer examples, it functions as a supplement to the clause. *I've dropped it* and *that hurt* are already complete: the reaction fills no argument or integrated modifier position within them. These are two characteristic environments for the lexical category INTERJECTION.

I take *ah*, *hey*, *oh*, *oops*, *ouch*, *sh*, *ugh*, and *wow*, in the uses *CGEL* describes (exclamations on their own or as supplements), as a working core. *CGEL* identifies these as central members and attributes both independent and supplementary use to them (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1361). Its additional example *alas* illustrates how a dated form can be a secure member. Here, CORE concerns the support for those assignments, rather than frequency or typicality.

Membership rests on several fallible diagnostics, as it does for any lexical category. *CGEL* assigns lexemes to categories "on the basis of their inflection, the kinds of dependent they take and the function in larger constructions of the phrases they head" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 30). Interjections characteristically take no inflection or derivation (Ameka, 1992, p. 106) and no dependents, with one exceptional type discussed in Section 2.3, and they occur on their own or as supplements. *CGEL*'s general definition adds meaning: interjections "do not combine with other words in integrated syntactic constructions, and have expressive rather than propositional meaning" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1361). *CGEL* reserves meaning for definitions of that general, cross-linguistic kind and decides which English words belong by their form (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 31–32), and Ameka (1992, pp. 105–106) and Wilkins (1992, pp. 124–125) likewise characterize the class through its distributional and morphological profile. I treat meaning as one of the converging diagnostics, as *CGEL*'s own treatment of *damn* in Section 2.3 does in practice. Most of these diagnostics are absences (no inflection, no dependents, no integrated position, no propositional content), and an absence weighs in the convergence like any other property.

No one diagnostic decides membership. Ordinary *Stop!* is an imperative clause: the verb retains the possibilities illustrated by *Stop the car!* and *Don't stop!*. A reply *Coffee* to *What would you like?* retains nominal organization, also visible in *Some coffee*, and Wilkins (1992, pp. 124–125) draws the same contrast with adjectival *Black* as an answer to a question about colour. Utterance status alone doesn't reclassify a word. Expressive meaning alone doesn't either: prenominal *damn* is expressive and isn't an interjection (Section 2.3).

A category has its place in a grammar because it lets a grammarian "make general statements about words" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 30). For interjections the statements concern this cluster of properties, and because the properties co-occur, observing some of them in a member licenses expecting the others. An analyst who has met reaction *ouch* only as an independent utterance, uninflected and reacting to pain, can expect it also to supplement an intact clause. From an identified supplementary *oops*, the analyst can expect an independent utterance without recovering a missing predicate. The absences project as well. An analyst who's seen *ouch* take no complement or modifier and no inflection hasn't thereby seen it with a determiner or a plural, and membership licenses expecting neither (**every ouch*, **two ouches*). A token such as *It's a big ouch*, attested in child-directed speech (Stange, 2016, p. 36), then needs a conversion analysis with evidence of its own rather than an exemption.

Meaning is a diagnostic and also a target of projection. For a form identified without it, membership supports expectations about which meanings to look for. Members characteristically express reactions, give voice to affective or cognitive states, or seek a listener's attention or action: a speaker can use *Ouch!* to react to pain, *Hey!* to attract attention, and *Sh!* to request silence. Ameka (1992, pp. 113–115) distinguishes expressive, conative, and phatic functions while allowing overlap. *CGEL*'s general definition is broad enough to cover all three, and the conative meaning of *sh* counts toward its membership even without the evaluative or affective stance that defines the narrower expressive grouping of Section 2.3. The category gives an initial expectation about the range of contributions; the narrower groupings specify which one.

The expectations extend to realization. Interjections characteristically form their own intonation units, including when they accompany another utterance (Ameka, 1992, p. 108). The core also admits conventional forms whose sounds are unusual elsewhere in English: *sh* can lack a vowel (Ameka, 1992, pp. 105–106), and *ugh* can contain a consonant absent from the usual standard British and American English inventories (Quirk et al., 1985, pp. 74, 853). These expectations differ in strength. Separate intonational packaging is characteristic; unusual segmental phonology is a recurrent possibility alongside ordinary sound patterns. The descriptions support this qualitative profile without supplying numerical probabilities, and Section 4 develops the relations of sound shape and prosodic packaging. Like meaning, these properties can also help assign a case, provided the same observation isn't then counted as confirming the expectation.

In each of these inferences the source and the target have to be kept apart. A property that helped assign a case can't also confirm the expectation that membership supplies about it. Where an assignment was made without using the target property, membership can guide expectations about that property. Wilkins (1992, p. 124) secures the same separation for the whole class, defining it by formal criteria alone so that its semantic and pragmatic regularities stay open to test. Applying the rule to each inference instead lets meaning help assign one case and be predicted for another.[1]

[1] The category assignment can itself be disputed. Wilkins (1992, 126–127 n. 5) treats *oh* in *Oh, don't go on like an*

2.2 Category and syntactic function

A syntactician also asks what an expression does in a construction. *CGEL* distinguishes category, such as noun phrase, from function, such as subject or object: expressions of the same category can have different functions, and different categories can realize the same function (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 23). Interjections participate in this familiar crosscutting. Interjection identifies a lexical category; supplement identifies a function.

Compare the interjection with the relative clause and noun phrase in these examples, adapted from *CGEL* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1356–1357, 1360).

(2) a. *Ah, so you were there after all!*
b. *We called in to see Sue's parents, which made us rather late.*
c. *A university lecturer, Dr Brown, was arrested for the crime.*

The highlighted expressions differ in category and internal structure, but each supplements an anchor. The interjection and relative clause have clausal anchors; *Dr Brown* has the noun phrase *a university lecturer* as its anchor. Functional classification groups them by that relation. Category classification preserves differences relevant to their internal organization and distribution elsewhere.

Supplement function supports inferences of its own. In the central cases, supplements are intonationally separate from the surrounding sentence (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1350). A supplementary analysis can be established without prosody: the anchor is complete, and the expression falls outside the scope of negatives in the anchor and can't be the focus of an *it*-cleft (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1360). That analysis gives reason to expect the packaging whether the expression is an interjection, a noun phrase, or a relative clause. This expectation reaches beyond the interjection inventory. It also explains why intonational separation alone doesn't identify an interjection.

Category can also stay constant while function changes. In *Dr Brown was arrested for the crime*, the same noun phrase functions as subject. Its category doesn't require the detached packaging expected of the supplement in (2c). A functional assignment concerns the expression's relation in a construction; the noun phrase retains its category across those different relations.

Part of the interjection's wider profile is shared through its supplement function. Knowing its lexical category supports an expectation that it can supplement a clause; knowing that it functions as a supplement supports an expectation about that occurrence's packaging. Neither classification has to predict something unavailable from every other description to be useful.

An independent *Ah!* supplies a contrasting environment for the same lexical category. Independent utterance is a constructional status here, not an additional syntactic function. The category records possibilities across environments; the functional analysis identifies a relation within one.

2.3 Expressive commonality across the category boundary

Standalone *Damn!* and supplementary *damn* in *Damn, we're going to be late!* extend the comparison to a form with an independently available verbal use. *CGEL* counts *damn* among words that are "primarily verbs" but in supplements like this one "have lost their verbal meaning, and are best regarded as having been reanalysed as interjections" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1361); standalone

old fool as a particle use, while reporting Ameka's co-utterance analysis. The core claim concerns identified conventional uses, not every occurrence of a spelling.

Damn! invites the same analysis. Their distribution and that loss of verbal meaning link them to the core; their conveyed stance links them to expressive uses elsewhere in the language.

Prenominal *damn*, in *the damn car*, occurs inside the noun phrase while contributing an attitude. Potts (2007, pp. 166, 181) distinguishes that expressive contribution from descriptive content. Supplementary *damn* and the prenominal modifier differ in function and in integration: a supplement isn't integrated into the syntactic structure of its sentence (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1350), and the modifier is. Standalone *Damn!* shares the supplement's lack of integration but has no anchor, being an independent utterance. The expressive analysis groups all three. In prenominal position *damn* is integrated into the noun phrase and lacks a supplement's separate packaging, and those diagnostics converge against membership in the interjection category. Its lack of inflection and dependents weighs toward membership, but not enough to outweigh them. I leave open which category it does belong to.

Complement-taking *Damn these mosquitoes!* presents a further question about the head's category, and here the diagnostics diverge. The noun-phrase complement looks verbal, and *CGEL* notes that "the verbal origin is more relevant" in this construction (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, 1361 n. 70). The phrase's external detachment, and the absence of any understood subject, look interjectional, and the plain form gives inflection no chance to show. *CGEL* tentatively treats the head as an exceptional interjection taking a noun-phrase complement, while a verbal analysis keeps the complement's evidence. On a converging account an unresolved assignment is the expected result here. This disagreement concerns the head's lexical category and its complementation; recognizing expressive commonality with the other *damn* uses leaves it intact.

The grouping here is EXPRESSIVE SIGNS, a semantic category anchored in conveyed stance: its members' deployment conveys an evaluative or affective stance rather than describing it. I use EXPRESSIVE in this narrower sense from here on; a conventional instruction for managing interpretation or interaction is non-propositional without necessarily expressing such a stance. Like a proper name, the category has a cluster. Potts (2007, pp. 166–167) lists six properties of expressives, and several are absences. Expressive content isn't part of the descriptive content, isn't interpreted in the scope of negation, conditionals, modals, or tense (Potts, 2007, pp. 170–171), and resists satisfactory paraphrase in descriptive terms. It's also evaluated from a perspective, usually the speaker's, takes effect in being uttered, and strengthens rather than becoming redundant when repeated. Among the category's properties of another kind is membership in the lexical category interjection, with the independent or supplementary use that goes with it. For *damn*, these properties raise the questions of whose attitude is conveyed, whether *The damn car didn't start* still conveys it despite the negation, and whether repeating the form strengthens it, on either side of the category boundary.

The expressive grouping and the lexical category come apart in both directions, as names and proper nouns do. The category's core includes conative uses for which the stance isn't required, and prenominal *damn* is an expressive realized outside the category, much as *the University of Manchester* is a name headed by a common noun. A fuller account of expressives can include integrated signs with no traditional interjection label. Selecting examples from interjection disputes lets us compare the two groupings without making the traditional label a condition on the expressive one.

Cognitive uses mark a further difference inside the category. Someone touches a hot pan and says *Ouch!*; someone finds missing keys under a newspaper and says *Aha!*. Ameka (1992, p. 113) gives the forms as examples of emotive and cognitive interjections: the first gives voice to a sensation, the

second displays a change in knowledge or recognition. His mental-state grouping is broader than the stance grouping used here, since finding the keys can be displayed with *Aha!* without conventionally evaluating them. That reading motivates a cognitive subtype; it doesn't prevent another occurrence from also conveying affect.

2.4 Expressive and depictive signs

Compare the selected expressive use of *Damn!* with a sound depiction *Bang!* in a narrative. The bearer in each case is the conventional use, not every occurrence of the spelling. The question is what contribution the use makes to interpretation. The strongest simple alternative groups both in one exclamatory class on the basis of their vividness and standalone packaging. That alternative still has to explain the difference between conveying an attitude and presenting a sound.

A depictive sign conventionally presents a sound, event, or sensory scene through a resemblance between aspects of its performance and what it depicts. Dingemanse's account of ideophones supplies the wider comparison: conventional lexical items can depict sensory imagery, and their word-class status varies by language, some languages giving them a class of their own (Dingemanse, 2018, pp. 2–3). The term expressive is itself used for ideophones in some traditions; that usage doesn't identify them with Potts's expressives.

For the selected *Bang!*, the relevant contribution is a portrayal of an impact sound. For *Damn!*, it's the conveyed stance toward a situation. The distinction changes how repetition is interpreted. In a narrative, *bang, bang, bang* can multiply portrayed impacts, while repeated *damn* can strengthen the conveyed stance.

The literature motivates those different targets. Potts treats repetition as potentially strengthening expressive contribution (Potts, 2007, pp. 167, 182), and Dingemanse connects depictive performance with iconic mappings between form and scene (Dingemanse, 2018, pp. 10–11). Potts's generalization gives reason to expect intensification for his expressive cases, while the depictive comparison asks how repeated performance maps onto the portrayed scene. The projected behaviour has to stay distinct from the assignment evidence: identifying a use as depictive from its response to repetition and then predicting that response would recycle the observation.

Separate expressive and depictive groupings preserve this difference, which an undifferentiated exclamatory class omits. One superordinate class, with the difference recorded as subtypes or dimensions, would serve the descriptive task as well, provided it kept both relations. The result requires the distinction, at whatever taxonomic rank.

The groupings also needn't be disjoint. A depiction can convey an attitude, and an expressive performance can exploit resemblance. What matters is whether the relevant contribution is conventional in the selected use and what follows from it. One inquiry into meaning can need both groupings, and more, so no single category answers every question about what a use contributes.

2.5 Contribution, encoding, and competing analyses

Consider the utterance *The damn car won't start*, said after several failed attempts at ignition. The speaker reports a starting problem and conveys a negative attitude. Calling *damn* expressive identifies that second contribution. Asking how the wording helps a hearer recover the attitude raises a different question about its encoding.

Wharton (2016) develops a procedural account of expressive meaning, connecting guidance for interpretation with the showing of emotion. Applied to the car example, such an account would treat

damn as a cue for recognizing the attitude being shown. The use could then be expressive in contribution and procedural in encoding. Those descriptions would answer different questions about the same utterance.

Now imagine a narrator representing the car's backfire with *Bang!*. The sign depicts a noise, and its performance can resemble what it depicts. That iconic presentation differs from *damn*'s conveyed stance. Identifying the depiction still leaves open how the sign guides interpretation: resemblance alone doesn't decide whether it supplies conceptual content, an interpretive procedure, or some combination.

Two accounts would compete if they made exclusive claims about the same *damn* use. Suppose one assigned it only conceptual content, such as a negative evaluation, while the other assigned it only a procedure for recognizing an attitude. These are hypothetical rivals, not summaries of Potts and Wharton. The first needn't make annoyance part of what the sentence asserts. Their incompatible claims about encoding would require adjudication.

2.6 Classes of sequential action

Consider two exchanges. A teller says *I tried the front door*, a listener responds *Mm-hm*, and the teller continues *but it was locked*. The listener supports continuation of the story. In a second exchange, someone says *We meet at five*; a recipient who missed the time responds *Huh?*, and the first speaker repeats *At five*. Here the response prompts repair.

The difference concerns what happens next: the story proceeds after the continuer, while the meeting time is repeated after the repair initiator. Closing *bye* has another job, participating in the end of an encounter. Accounts of interjections in conversation make these sequential differences central (Dingemanse, 2024, pp. 257–259, 263–265), and part of each class's profile is what its members don't do. A continuer provides evidence of attention "without attempting to take the conversational floor" (Dingemanse, 2024, p. 266), and *huh?*, "the most generic way of asking for clarification", leaves the trouble in the prior turn unlocated (Dingemanse, 2024, p. 267). Membership in the lexical category can orient expectations toward reactive or interaction-managing uses; these finer categories identify the particular sequential relation.

For comparison, these can be collected as conventional action formats: non-elliptical resources that can perform their action without a lexically specified host. This working grouping collects resources whose particular sequential consequences need separate characterization. Predictions about whether another turn continues a story or repairs an utterance belong to particular resource classes and environments. A broader grouping can remain informative at a coarser level without deciding between them.

The criterion has consequences at the boundary. Response *okay* and closing or thanking *thanks* are candidates insofar as their selected uses conventionally perform the relevant action. A formulaic greeting *how are you?* can qualify despite having several words. An ordinary imperative *stop!* doesn't qualify merely because clause structure permits it to stand alone; a claim that it's also a conventional routine needs evidence beyond that structure.

Host-dependent *please* in *please sit down* belongs to a different comparison. A standalone appeal *Please!* would have to be assessed as that selected use.

Assigning *mm-hm* and *huh?* to the lexical category needs the same converging evidence as the core, since standalone occurrence alone doesn't classify a word. Absence of inflection and dependents weighs for membership, though less in standalone responses, where a rival analysis wouldn't

show them either (Section 3). The assignment rests on the non-elliptical analysis adopted here, under which neither needs a recovered nominal head or clause to supply its interpretation, and on their non-propositional meaning. Ameka (1992, p. 114) includes the former among phatic interjections, and Wilkins (1992, p. 152) treats repair *huh?* as a conventional utterance. The assignments in Table 1 are defeasible analyses supported by these descriptions.

Routine formulae expose competition within an inquiry. Ameka (1992, pp. 108–110) separates *bye*, *sorry*, and *thank you* from interjections, whereas Wilkins (1992, p. 142) treats routines as a subtype. Their disagreement is about which diagnostics count: Wilkins admits routines on the formal profile they share with interjections, while Ameka gives decisive weight to their addressees, their social predictability, and their status as speech acts. The selected closing format can be compared with continuers without settling whether the wider grouping is the most useful category for either question.

2.7 Bearers, relations, and distinct questions

A SIGN-TYPE is an identifiable expression in a conventional use. Its PROFILE is the set of properties attributed to it: the constructions its occurrences enter, its contribution to interpretation, its sequential uses, its conventional sound shape, and others. A use can retain its identity while a proposed property turns out to be absent. Otherwise every surprising observation would identify a different object and leave the original proposal immune to correction.

The recurrent contrast between standalone and prenominal *damn* supports distinguishing their conventional uses. Table 1 separates category from function or constructional status. The category column concerns the listed expression, whether a lexical item, phrase, or clause. In *damn* + *NP*, it concerns the head *damn*; the whole phrase's distribution remains a distinct observation.

A function belongs to an expression in a constructional relation, and the sign-type's profile records which relations its realizations can enter. The table's status descriptions keep independent utterance distinct from syntactic function.

The table records crossings within syntax as well as across inquiries. Supplement function connects interjections, a noun phrase, and a relative clause. The lexical category's core groups reactions with conatives. Expressive classification connects standalone and prenominal *damn*, while stance and depiction distinguish contributions within meaning.

Bang! makes the unresolved category question concrete. English also has nominal *bang*, as in *a loud bang* and *two bangs*. A standalone occurrence needs assessment against a nominal-fragment analysis. Its depictive interpretation can be recognized while that question remains open. Section 4 completes the related assessment of what phonological evidence can decide.

3 What warrants a class, a category, or an explanation?

Membership in the lexical category supports expectations about distribution, characteristic contributions, and forms of realization. Supplement function supports expectations across lexical and phrasal categories. Expressive classification supports its own expectations, about perspective and repetition, for uses on both sides of the category boundary; the expressive–depictive comparison distinguishes further relations within meaning. Each grouping can supply information relevant to another inquiry. Assessing the particular inferences explains both their usefulness and their limits: the groupings overlap without becoming interchangeable, and reliable associations still leave their causal explanation open.

Table 1: Category, syntactic function or status, and meaning or sequential action. Functional assignments concern the indicated constructions; independent utterance is a status, not a syntactic function.

Expression or use	Category	Function or status	Meaning or action
Reaction *ouch*; *oops*	Interjection	Supplement to a clause; also independent utterance	Pain or mishap reaction
Attention-getting *hey*; silencing *sh*	Interjection	Supplement to a clause; also independent utterance	Conative: attention or silence
gee; stance *damn*	Interjection	Supplement to a clause; also independent utterance	Expressive stance
damn in *damn + NP*	Interjection or verb; unresolved	Head taking an NP complement	Expressive contribution
Prenominal *damn*	Not interjection; otherwise left open	Modifier within the noun phrase	Expressive contribution
Continuer *mm-hm*	Interjection analysis adopted	Independent utterance in the exchange	Continuation resource
Repair *huh?*	Interjection analysis adopted	Independent utterance in the exchange	Open repair initiator
Closing *bye*	Left open here	Independent formulaic utterance	Closing resource
Depictive *Bang!*	Interjection or noun; unresolved	Independent utterance; fragment analysis open	Sound depiction
which made us rather late in (2b)	Relative clause	Supplement to the preceding clause	Consequence of the visit
Dr Brown in (2c)	Noun phrase	Supplement to *a university lecturer*	Identification of the lecturer

3.1 Bearers, grouping, achievement, and alternatives

Four questions organize the assessment. What bears membership? What groups the members? What does the grouping help an investigator distinguish, infer, or explain? And what alternative would serve the same inquiry? Each proposal also needs a scope: a language or community, relevant conditions, and, where the claim concerns change, a period. These questions apply to established proposals and new candidates alike.

The BEARER is the object grouped. Two recordings of *The damn car won't start* contain two realizations of the selected prenominal *damn* use. Counting the recordings gives two occurrences, not two sign-types. A phonetician can classify the individual productions; a lexical inquiry can ask about the conventional use they realize. A syntactic inquiry can classify the noun phrase containing it and the relations among its constituents. A historian may instead classify a change connecting an earlier sign with a later one.

Functional classification identifies an expression together with its constructional relation, as with *Dr Brown* as supplement and as subject (Section 2.2). Functions can also group complex expressions, such as the relative clause in (2b), whose whole wording needn't be conventionalized.

The GROUPING BASIS supplies the assignment evidence. For both groupings it's a convergence of fallible diagnostics, and they differ in the property each is anchored in: distribution and morphology for the lexical category, conveyed stance for the expressive grouping. Prenominal *damn* enters the expressive grouping on its conveyed stance and the properties that accompany it, while its position inside *the damn car* is evidence about its function. Grouping it with standalone *Damn!* for the first reason doesn't erase their difference in the second respect. Other proposals can use ancestry or participation in a social repertoire; each needs to identify the relation its membership records.

Evidence of one kind can support expectations of another. Evidence about distribution, morphology, and meaning can assign a sign-type to the lexical category before its prosody has been examined, and the category's established profile then supports an expectation about its packaging. Conversely, expressive contribution can motivate a comparison between *damn* uses on either side of the category boundary. Nor does remaining within syntax select between lexical-category, phrasal-category, and functional classifications.

The ACHIEVEMENT identifies what the grouping accomplishes. A constructed class can fix a comparison set. A descriptive class can organize a recurrent relation across independently identified cases. A category claim requires evidence that co-occurring properties support induction beyond the application conditions. A causal claim requires evidence about the process producing an outcome. These achievements can accumulate, but evidence for an earlier one doesn't establish a later one automatically.

Descriptive success can be assessed before any projection is tested. The expressive grouping preserves a shared contribution across standalone and integrated uses; the expressive–depictive contrast records different contributions concealed by the broad cover term. Those descriptive achievements establish which similarities an adequate account needs to preserve. Further projections can build on them, with their warrant assessed against the evidence for the particular expectation.

An ALTERNATIVE can be a broader class, narrower subtypes, a continuous dimension, or an item-by-item account. In the expressive–depictive comparison, separate classes and a superordinate class with explicit subtypes both preserve the decisive distinction. For an inquiry into recipient responses, action-specific groupings may be more informative than their union. The number and rank of cat-

egories are outcomes of comparison.

Table 2: Assessing the expressive grouping without conflating its achievements

Question	Proposed answer	Evidential consequence
Bearer	Conventional uses, including standalone and prenominal *damn*	Identify each use without requiring the target property under investigation.
Grouping	Deployment conventionally conveys evaluative or affective stance	Distinguish this from describing an emotion, depicting a scene, or managing interaction.
Achievement	Preserve expressive commonality across the category boundary	Distinguish the observed contrast from its extension to new realizations, environments, or sign-types.
Alternative	An undifferentiated interjection class, explicit subtypes, or item-specific accounts	Compare which differences in contribution each preserves and what further generalization each warrants.

3.2 From proposal to category claim

An admission rule fixes which cases enter a class. A category claim makes a further commitment: membership supports informative expectations beyond the evidence used to assign it. Assembling a grouping and warranting those expectations can succeed or fail separately. Here, category standing names the latter achievement; it isn't a verdict on whether a descriptive class is scientifically useful.

Three comparisons distinguish the reach of an expectation. After identifying the expressive contribution in *The damn car won't start*, an investigator could examine another speaker's utterance of that sentence, the question *Has the damn car broken down?*, or *The bloody car won't start*. These comparisons change the realization, the environment, and the expression respectively.

The question supplies a concrete target: does the negative stance remain conveyed while the car's breakdown is put in question? Evidence from declaratives needn't settle that. The investigator can test the familiar property in a new environment without inventing a differently named property. Generalizing to independently identified *bloody* makes a further commitment across sign-types. Neither move is licensed simply by defining the class to contain the desired cases.

An additional shared property isn't sufficient merely because it's additional. If all members and nearly every sign outside a proposed grouping exhibit the target repetition behavior, membership supplies little additional guidance about it. An imperfect probabilistic association can be informative when it changes a warranted expectation at the stated scope. The alternatives in the preceding section help assess that gain.

This comparison concerns what membership licenses an investigator to expect; whether a category representation improves a particular model is a separate question, taken up below. In either case, support for a subtype doesn't automatically extend to its superordinate class.

For the lexical category in Section 2.1, the reach includes both use across constructions and associations with meaning and realization. The descriptions that warrant these expectations combine observations of distribution, meaning, and sound. What matters for each expectation is whether

the projected property helped assign the case. The category's place in the grammar rests on general statements about its members' constructions, morphology, meaning, and realization. Any of these can be the source of one inference and the target of another. Functional groupings have comparable reach: supplementary status supports an expectation about prosodic detachment across expression categories.

The source evidence matters for each inference. An assignment established from distribution, morphology, and meaning can support an expectation about an unexamined intonation boundary. If that boundary helped identify the case, predicting it adds nothing; characteristic packaging can instead be assessed in another realization. This distinction concerns what was observed and what's projected.

I also adopt the action-specific categories for the sequential relations documented in the cited descriptions. The same evidential policy applies across inquiries: established descriptions can warrant scoped projections about a use's contribution or its sequential consequences.

3.3 Projection and identity

Revising the analysis of a conventional use can improve subsequent predictions without turning an earlier failure into a success. To keep those judgments separate, a projective claim states what's been observed, what's expected, and over which bearers and conditions. Its WARRANT is the evidence supporting that expectation (Goodman, 1955). Claim content, evidential status, and proposed causal ground can then be assessed separately (Reynolds, 2026, pp. 11–12).

Suppose source contexts identify an expressive use and the target is its interpretation under repetition. Repetition can't also supply the case-level evidence used to admit that use. Similarly, if resistance to determiner combination is the target, an unexpected determiner can't by itself justify excluding the case as conversion. A change to the identification rule creates a revised claim requiring assessment.

Imagine an investigator who's identified expressive *damn* only in standalone reactions such as *Damn! We've missed the train*. Their provisional identification uses the reaction meaning; it doesn't require standalone position. They predict that these uses resist integration into a phrase. Encountering *The damn car won't start* then presents an adverse case: the expression conveys stance while functioning as an integrated modifier inside the noun phrase.

The investigator should check the structural analysis, but the confirmed prenominal occurrence counts against the restriction under the original identification rule. Its inconvenient distribution isn't by itself a reason to remove it from that assessment. For the lexical category, integration is itself a diagnostic, so the same position counts against prenominal *damn*'s membership rather than against a projection. Later recognizing a distinct prenominal use can improve the analysis without making the original prediction successful.

An informative restriction also needs relevant opportunities. Failure to observe inflection says little if the sampled environments wouldn't elicit it under a rival analysis. Testing distribution requires relevant constructions; testing a sequential expectation requires the relevant sequential environments. Either prediction can start from evidence of membership in a category established for another inquiry. Both claims then concern the same use, and each is assessed on its own evidence.

3.4 Representation and causal explanation

Suppose an inventory records that a use occurs standalone and conveys stance. Adding the label "standalone stance use" abbreviates those two observations; it adds no information to a fully observed record. The combined grouping could still be useful when investigating something not yet recorded, such as interpretation under repetition. Pooling observations from its members might help estimate that pattern from sparse records.

The grouping selects an intersection: stance *Damn!* qualifies, while prenominal *damn* in *the damn car* fails the standalone condition. A model can represent that intersection as one label or keep its two component assignments. Their relative value depends on the information available and the target being predicted. A benefit for estimating repetition behavior wouldn't establish a unique cause of the shared properties or priority for every inquiry.

Explanation asks another question. Once the present form of *gee* has been recorded, knowing its religious source adds nothing to that already observed spelling. Its history can still explain how the form arose. More generally, conditioning a prediction on consequences of a historical process can remove the association through which that process is recognized. Section 5 distinguishes this predictive comparison from assessment of the proposed history itself.

4 Phonological organization and situated realization

Membership in the lexical category is informative about conventional sound shape and the packaging of realizations, as well as distribution. Its characteristic profile includes separate intonational packaging and an openness to sounds or combinations unusual elsewhere in a variety. A phonological inquiry can pursue those associations and also group signs across lexical categories. Even where the lexical category of depictive *Bang!* remains unsettled, its conventional sound shape and its productions are available for comparison.

These observations motivate different classifications. The first can group sign-types by their phonological possibilities. The second groups realizations by how speakers produce them in context. Their relation connects the resources available for a conventional sign with the ways speakers realize it on particular occasions.

4.1 A phonological stratum of signs

English conversational clicks make the first possibility concrete. The click represented by *tut-tut* differs from an ordinary spelling pronunciation (Wilkins, 1992, p. 147). Forms such as *ugh* permit sounds outside the usual phoneme inventory of standard British and American English (Quirk et al., 1985, pp. 74, 853). A phonological inquiry can ask which conventional signs admit such resources, how their variants are organized, and how speakers acquire or adapt them.

These possibilities belong to the interjection profile. Having assigned a sign-type to the lexical category, an investigator has reason to consider a wider range of conventional sound patterns than the ordinary word phonology would allow (Ameka, 1992, pp. 105–106). Some members use that range and others have ordinary phonology. Membership guides expectations without predicting an anomalous segment in every item.

Ameka (1992, pp. 112–113) diagnoses a different inference: unusual phonology shared with interjections has been used to include onomatopoeic words in the lexical category. His alternative recognizes a phonological grouping whose members can belong to different lexical categories. The

forward association and this objection are compatible: membership in the category can inform phonological expectations without unusual phonology being sufficient for membership.

Unusual phonology is weak evidence for membership by itself, since it's shared with onomatopoeic words of other categories. Nor does sound depiction entail phonological anomaly: resemblance and distribution within the sound system are different relations.

The reverse inference can also have value as defeasible evidence. Its strength depends on how the observed phonological property is distributed among competing category analyses. Evidence that interjections permit unusual sounds doesn't by itself settle how diagnostic an unusual sound is of interjectionhood. That question concerns the association and its alternatives, rather than a prohibition on inference across domains.

For English *Bang!*, the competing analysis is a standalone nominal fragment, supported as a possibility by the independently available noun in *a loud bang*. A depictive interpretation leaves that analysis open. Even if an occurrence had unusual phonation, the additional observation would concern its realization. Choosing between nominal and interjectional analyses needs converging evidence about the selected use, such as number contrast and nominal dependents, or a warranted association with its phonology. Its depictive meaning doesn't discriminate here, because both analyses allow it.

A broad class of phonologically unusual forms, with lexical category recorded separately, loses nothing for known cases. It fails only if membership in it is treated as sufficient for interjection status. Establishing one projectible phonological stratum would require its own family of supported expectations.

An account of the stratum would gain projective reach if membership organized acquisition, adaptation, or alternation beyond the diagnostic used to identify it. Consider the contrast between producing a click and pronouncing *tut-tut* as spelled words. An investigation could first group signs by independently recorded articulations, then ask which permit a spelling pronunciation and in what settings. That prospective comparison would test a relation beyond the articulation used for grouping; the reported alternatives don't yet establish it.

Regular phonology matters too. In a ten-language study of open repair interjections, Dingemanse et al. (2013) find broad phonetic similarities alongside language-specific vowel targets and intonation. The repair interjections in Icelandic and Cha'palaa have falling contours, consistent with local interrogative prosody. The study concerns comparable repair environments. It supplies no reason to assign every form resembling *huh* to one phonologically exceptional class.

Phonological classification thus has work to do within ordinary linguistic organization as well as at its margins. An inquiry into repair intonation could group forms with interrogative resources; another into unusual segments could group conversational clicks with other marked forms. Both could be useful. A single label for both would obscure the difference unless the inquiry and grouping basis were specified.

4.2 Prosodic classes of realizations

A prosodic boundary is a property of a realization, and a sign-type's characteristic packaging supports expectations about its realizations. For an independently identified interjection, separate intonational phrasing is a reasonable default (Ameka, 1992, p. 108), with variation across environments. Realizations of signs in different categories can share a boundary pattern. Supplements provide a familiar example: interjections, noun phrases, and relative clauses can all be prosodically detached (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 66, 1350).

Here functional classification connects category with realization (Section 2.2). An interjection's distribution includes supplementary use; supplementary status in turn supports a prosodic expectation shared with other expression categories. Once the function is known, lexical category needn't add a further prediction about that same boundary to remain useful for other properties.

Take a recording of *Damn, we're going to be late!*. The context can identify the reaction use while the acoustic record supplies evidence about a boundary, such as a pause or pitch movement. A second recording can realize the same use with different timing. The category supplies an expectation before each boundary is measured; the recordings show whether and how it's realized. Estimating the strength of that tendency requires productions across relevant environments.

Interaction supplies some of those environments. Ogden (2013) describes English clicks and percussives in stance-taking, sequence management, word searches, and turn timing, with visual behaviour contributing to their interpretation. A classification of productions by timing and articulation can intersect an analysis of sequential practices. The range of jobs also cautions against assigning one conventional action or expressive meaning to every click.

The comma in a transcript of *Damn, we're going to be late!* is a different kind of observation. It may record a transcriber's analysis of detachment, but it isn't itself a pause or a syntactic relation. Entering that comma once as a prosodic boundary and again as syntactic non-integration would manufacture apparent agreement between the measures. An acoustic analysis and a constructional analysis can converge without relying on that single transcription decision.

The two sound-based inquiries connect to the lexical classifications in different ways. Phonological strata can share their sign-type bearers and enter membership intersections. Prosodic classes of occurrences connect to them through realization and through distributions over contexts. A sign-type table can record a propensity for separate intonational packaging. Keeping that propensity distinct from each realized boundary lets the table support a prediction whose outcome can be checked.

5 Historical ancestry and classes of change

The history of *gee* explains a feature of its present form that a synchronic interjection label leaves unexplained. Signs with different current distributions can descend from related sources, while signs with similar current profiles can arrive by different routes.

A historical inquiry can classify present signs by independently established ancestry. It can also classify changes, such as clipping or reanalysis. The first has sign-types as bearers; the second has changes linking sources and outcomes.

5.1 The documented route to *gee*

Gehweiler (2008) traces *gee* through an invocation of *Jesus*, an exclamatory use of the religious name, and a clipped form. In the invocation, the speaker addresses the deity. The exclamation can express a reaction without that address. Clipping then produces a form whose relation to the name can become opaque. The sequence separates semantic change from the later change of form.

The transitions also have different proposed explanations. Gehweiler relates the first to gradual invited inference, aided by the syntactically peripheral invocation. She analyzes the clipping as an abrupt, taboo-motivated change involving hearer reanalysis (Gehweiler, 2008, pp. 84–88). The route also bears on the interjection's present distribution. Invocational *Jesus* "typically stands utterance-initially" and is set apart from the rest of the utterance (Gehweiler, 2008, p. 85). I take the peripheral

packaging of *gee* to continue the invocation's, so it didn't have to be acquired with the change of category.

The history explains why the shape of *gee* bears a relation to religious invocation even for a speaker who doesn't recognize that relation. Its present opacity alone wouldn't identify its ancestry. The documented sequence supplies the additional evidence for a restricted instance of path dependence: a particular route helps explain a feature of its outcome, without making every other outcome of that route predictable.

The explanation concerns a particular outcome. It doesn't yet establish that a class of signs with religious ancestry outperforms alternatives or supports a common projection. That comparison would require independently documented histories and outcomes across more than this one route.

The distinction also corrects an ambiguity in PRIMARY and SECONDARY interjections. Ameka's distinction concerns whether a form has other, non-interjectional uses in the language (Ameka, 1992, pp. 105–106). It isn't a partition into historically underived and historically derived signs. Gehweiler's primary *gee* has a documented derived history. Conversely, an unknown etymology supplies a gap in knowledge, not a common origin shared by all forms whose sources remain unknown.

5.2 Source, mechanism, transmission, and trajectory

A useful historical description separates four relations. The SOURCE identifies an earlier sign or construction. The MECHANISM specifies a change, such as clipping or reanalysis. The TRANSMISSION SETTING concerns how the innovation spreads, including borrowing where supported. The subsequent TRAJECTORY concerns further changes in use or form. Signs can share one relation without sharing the other three.

For *gee*, a religious invocation supplies the source and tabooistic clipping supplies one mechanism. Those facts don't establish the transmission history of every later community's use. Nor does a shared source force a common trajectory: an exclamatory religious name can remain phonologically close to its source without later undergoing clipping. Historical classes can be organized at several levels, according to which relation the inquiry needs.

The proposed verbal route to complement-taking *damn* illustrates unequal support among histories. *God damn him* has the shape of an optative, a construction independently recognized in English (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 944). Omission of the subject and increasing conventional expressive force offer a plausible route to *damn him*. The surviving complement fits that reconstruction. These synchronic comparisons don't establish the sequence as independently as Gehweiler's historical record does.

The source optative already uses plain-form *damn*, so the reconstruction doesn't require loss of tense marking at that transition. And the present complement remains compatible with competing analyses of the head as verbal or interjectional. A classification by independently established verbal ancestry would include the head whichever present analysis is right. Inferring the ancestry solely from the complement and then invoking the ancestry to predict that same complement would be circular.

Classes of changes require a different representation. An instance of clipping relates an earlier form to an outcome; an instance of semantic reanalysis relates earlier and later interpretations. Neither is itself a sign-type alongside *gee* and *damn*. A process classification can support comparisons among developments, while explicit source–result relations connect those developments to classifications of their inputs and outputs.

5.3 What historical evidence can establish

Historical explanation and forward projection need different comparisons. A documented route may explain a present feature through the changes that produced it. A forward projection asks what information about the route warrants expecting in another case. For a verbal-source class, that target could concern surviving restrictions on dependents, provided those restrictions weren't used to assign the source. The present examples motivate that inquiry without establishing a category-wide result.

Evidence for replication also needs to distinguish innovations from their descendants. Suppose one community coins a clipped exclamation and three others borrow it. Four community records then document one origin, not four independent instances of clipping. They can support an account of transmission or subsequent divergence. Testing whether the same source repeatedly gives rise to the same outcome would require independently established innovations. This hypothetical count makes the sampling unit depend on the historical claim.

An ancestry classification can still explain a present contrast even when ancestry adds no predictive information after all its consequences are observed. Conditioning on those consequences changes the question to whether ancestry adds any further information. That can be a useful test of predictive economy; it isn't a general test of whether the documented process occurred or helped produce the contrast.

Historical classes can have two kinds of payoff. They can organize independently supported source relations among present signs, and they can compare processes across developments. These are legitimate descriptive and explanatory achievements. An empirical ancestry category, in the stronger usage adopted here, also needs support for the inductions it licenses. The documented history of one sign can't supply that support for an entire source class.

6 Broader classes and further inquiries

The traditional interjection domain also intersects classes whose most informative members lie elsewhere. Social evaluation can group forms by their appropriateness for audiences and settings. Processing inquiries can group familiar expressions by how they're produced or understood. An interjection's membership in either class needn't make the class interjection-specific. Three questions remain distinct: whether the broader class is supported, how it intersects the traditional domain, and whether an INTERJECTION label helps describe that intersection.

6.1 Social evaluation and recognized repertoires

Religious exclamations connect the historical case to a further classification. In Gehweiler's account, taboo pressure contributes to clipping *Jesus* into *gee*. A present-day inquiry can group uses by their evaluated appropriateness for an audience or setting. It asks how speakers assess the available forms in their own community.

Jay and Janschewitz (2008) examine ratings of hypothetical swearing scenarios, finding that judgments depend on the word, speaker–listener relations, and social and physical context. These ratings support contextual differentiation in evaluations of taboo language.

Consider a proposed comparison of *Gee!* and *Jesus!* as reactions to surprising news among close friends and during a formal interview. Ratings would ask how appropriate each choice seems in each setting. A difference in those ratings would distinguish social appropriateness without by itself changing the reaction's lexical category.

Social indexing poses a related but distinct inquiry. Agha's account of enregisterment concerns the social recognition of speech forms as indexing attributes of speakers, with a repertoire's associations and social reach subject to change (Agha, 2005, pp. 38–40). A classification by participation in a recognized repertoire could cross divisions by lexical category, contribution, and sequential action. The relevant evidence concerns whether speakers recognize and use those associations; a difference in frequency between country collections doesn't show that.

For example, if listeners regularly associated *Gee!* with an old-fashioned speaker persona, their judgments would support a social association. They wouldn't merely be rating whether it was acceptable in the interview. Both investigations could concern the same surprise reaction, while asking different questions about its social meaning. Such associations could also unite forms used for several actions. Any claimed convention would need a specified community and evidence of shared recognition.

6.2 Formulaicity and processing

Compare a familiar greeting, *How are you?*, a pause filler, *um*, and the idiom *kick the bucket*. These forms differ in category, internal structure, and conversational job. A processing inquiry could ask whether speakers produce them as familiar routines. Its grouping would cross the earlier divisions by category and contribution; formulaic expressions might name it more clearly than another kind of interjection.

Van Lancker Sidtis et al. (2015) report differences in formulaic language production and comprehension across clinical groups and healthy participants. Their production analysis combines six kinds of formulaic material, including conversational formulae, pause fillers, sentence stems, and idioms. The results give empirical consequences to a grouping that crosses lexical and phrasal categories: pause fillers can be studied alongside phrases and idioms despite their different categories and internal structure.

For the greeting, one question is whether *How are you?* is retrieved fluently because repeated use has helped establish a routine. A comparison at the same measured frequency asks how fluency differs among expressions with comparable recorded use. That adjustment doesn't by itself identify how much repetition contributed to the greeting's fluency. A causal interpretation still needs assumptions about exposure, retrieval, and how the frequency measure relates to speakers' experience.

Suppose retrieval across *How are you?*, *um*, and *kick the bucket* tracked familiarity more closely than any interjection grouping. That result would favour the broader or continuous representation for this processing inquiry. The category contrast would remain available for a different question, provided its own evidence held.

6.3 Further inquiries and their objects

Morphological analysis can distinguish a retained plural shape in exclamatory *heavens!* from a productive number contrast. Attested noun and verb uses of *ouch* in child-directed speech likewise make the conventional use consequential for lexical classification (Stange, 2016, p. 36). The lexical profile of a reaction doesn't describe every construction containing the same spelling.

Other inquiries change the object under investigation. A child's acquisition of *ouch* concerns a learner and a series of learning episodes. A recording of *Bye!* with a wave includes visible timing absent from a lexical inventory. In a comic panel, *BANG* can depict a noise without representing anyone's

speech. Learning, multimodal performance, and graphic depiction connect to conventional signs through different relations, each requiring its own comparison.

Annotation supplies a practical example. A tag can retrieve conversational responses while combining several lexical-category or contribution classes. Its success concerns retrieval under a coding policy. To use the retrieved tokens as evidence about a lexical category, an investigator needs to establish how that policy relates to category membership. The following measurement case shows the consequence of leaving that relation unchecked.

7 A measurement case: tags, strings, and uses

A retrieval class can be useful for a corpus query and still give a misleading picture when treated as a linguistic category. In the Corpus of Global Web-Based English (GloWbE), which contains country-labelled web sections (Davies & Fuchs, 2015), the spelling *ha* retrieves both reactions and abbreviations for hectares. A tag, a string, and a conventional use select different sets. The distinction changes the apparent geographical pattern.

The strings *12 ha of land* and *Ha! I knew it* make the difference visible. A search for the spelling *ha*, ignoring capitalization, can retrieve both. An investigation of the reaction use needs to distinguish them. A tag intended to make that distinction is still a measurement decision whose accuracy needs checking.

The *ha* record makes the consequence concrete. Some tagged occurrences abbreviate HECTARE, especially in agricultural prose. A rule-based screen of exported contexts changes Kenya's rank from fifth to fifteenth or sixteenth under six treatments of laughter and unclear cases; pooling gives ranks from fourteenth to sixteenth. The large movement is stable across those choices. Its exact size remains conditional on the screen and on the exported samples.

The screen was tuned against forty Kenyan and Tanzanian examples; its resulting 39/40 binary agreement is a development check. It doesn't establish equivalent accuracy in every country section. The observed geographic distribution depends on both the linguistic phenomenon and the measurement procedure. An analysis of category variation would need independently identified uses and comparable opportunities for their occurrence.

Similarly, changing frequency ranks in the Corpus of Historical American English (COHA) describe a tagged inventory (Davies, 2010). They don't establish persistence of any category's profile. Two further analyses, of derivative forms and of *fie*, can't bear confirmatory weight. The derivative pipeline assigned the meanings it was meant to measure, and the *fie* input retained ineligible optical character recognition substitutions.

The evidence supplement preserves the complete records: GloWbE measurement and model comparisons (Section A), the derivative audit (Section B), the *fie* audit (Section C), and inventory turnover (Section D). Its retained model comparison predicts an omitted country–item cell within the observed design; it doesn't assess new countries, new items, or the proposed linguistic groupings. These records locate the failure at the relevant claim. A useful retrieval class survives as a tool, but its output can't establish a linguistic category without evidence connecting that class to independently identified uses.

8 The general consequence

Membership in the lexical category interjection gives access to a wider profile: characteristic meanings and uses, a tendency toward separate intonational packaging, and possibilities for unusual phonology. These expectations extend the category's value beyond the general statements that give it a place in the grammar. A classification can be informative across several inquiries even when its members vary in the associated properties.

Within syntax, category and function preserve different generalizations. Supplement function connects an interjection with a noun phrase and a relative clause, supporting expectations about their packaging. Noun-phrase category connects supplementary *Dr Brown* with its subject use. The same syntactician needs both analyses. Some of the interjection's wider expectations are shared through its supplement function.

Variation in the associated properties leaves other groupings useful. Conative *sh* shares the category and distribution of *ouch* without requiring its reactive contribution. Prenominal *damn* shares expressive properties with standalone *Damn!* from outside the category. The relations are partly aligned: category membership guides expectations about meaning, while expressive classification connects uses on both sides of the category boundary.

Depictive *Bang!* introduces a further kind of contribution, and continuers and repair initiators are anchored in different next actions. A field can host several categories, each anchored in its own kind of property and counting properties of other kinds in its cluster; their number and extension depend on the questions and the evidence.

8.1 Many-to-many relations and local failure

Dupré's pluralism and Khalidi's crosscutting kinds make room for multiple defensible groupings. The linguistic cases add working rules: specify which relation a proposed grouping preserves and which objects participate in it, apply the source–target rule to each inference, and assess a projection under the identification rule in force when it was made. Haspelmath's division between descriptive categories and comparative concepts supplies a related lesson about analytical purpose. Here, the same care is needed within a language and within an inquiry.

In *The damn car won't start*, expressive contribution concerns the attitude conveyed; procedural encoding concerns how the wording guides its recognition. Both descriptions could hold. The contrast with depictive *Bang!* concerns a different contribution, while the exclusive encoding hypotheses in Section 2.5 disagree about the same use. Assigning the hypotheses to different fields wouldn't make their claims compatible.

Failure has correspondingly local consequences. Suppose a repetition test found that an independently identified expressive use didn't strengthen stance under the specified conditions. The prediction of intensification would fail there; the observed distinction between conveying stance and depicting a sound wouldn't disappear with it. Restricting the prediction to another subtype would create a new claim. Its support couldn't be inherited from the failed generalization.

The classifications are mutually informative without being interchangeable. Knowing that a use belongs to the lexical category interjection gives reason to expect parts of the wider profile. Knowing that it's expressive supports more specific expectations about stance, including for integrated uses such as prenominal *damn*. A phonological stratum can connect sign-types across lexical categories, and a prosodic classification can connect productions that those classifications separate.

8.2 Overlap, mechanisms, and category standing

Selecting standalone stance uses includes expressive *Damn!* and excludes prenominal *damn* in *the damn car*. That intersection is well-defined and can fix a useful comparison set. Its further value depends on the question: does restricting attention to those uses help with the proposed inference? Neither the overlap itself nor the availability of its component assignments answers that.

Distinct categories needn't be statistically independent, and they can share causal processes. A partial association can make membership in one informative about properties studied through another. Such associations are part of what makes the classifications useful. Strong correlation still leaves distinct questions and extensions; a shared history can help explain their alignment without establishing every present property.

For *Bang!*, uncertainty between a nominal-fragment and an interjection analysis doesn't itself establish graded membership. The analysis may simply be unresolved. A separate inquiry could ask how typical speakers judge it compared with *Damn!*; prototype accounts organize such typicality and similarity (Rosch, 1975; Taylor, 2003). Either a graded or a categorical representation can serve a task, but its form alone doesn't establish what it licenses an investigator to infer.

A field supplies no fixed quota of categories, and an inquiry needn't end with just one. A grouping may serve several questions across fields, but warrant only specified projections under specified conditions. The historical label INTERJECTION identifies a meeting point for these inquiries. It has a history of its own as a classification: Latin grammarians kept the interjection as a separate part of speech partly to preserve the Greek count of eight once Latin lacked articles (Bagli, 2026, p. 479). Bagli (2026, pp. 487–488) ranks Bullokar's account above the Ramist ones for descriptive adequacy, while granting that those are "internally coherent within their respective models". This account needs no ranking, since each grammar's grouping answered its own question. The bearers of that history are classifications in grammars, not signs, so it stays apart from the path dependence of forms in Section 5. The evidence, rather than the label or departmental boundary, determines which proposed categories deserve recognition.

9 Conclusion

English interjections support several classifications because the relevant properties recur in partially aligned patterns. Within syntax, lexical and phrasal categories crosscut functions: an interjection, a noun phrase, and a relative clause can all serve as supplements, with shared expectations about prosodic detachment.

Core members of the lexical category, including *ouch*, *oops*, *hey*, and *sh*, support expectations about independent utterance and clausal supplementation, and also about characteristic contributions and realization. Assigning a sign-type to the category once enough of these diagnostics converge gives reason to expect the rest: other environments, an affective or cognitive reaction or an attempt to direct attention or action, often its own intonational packaging, and possibilities for unusual phonology. The general statements that give the category its place in the grammar don't confine what membership lets an investigator expect.

Crosscutting classifications needn't be rival approximations to a single complete classification. Each is anchored in a different kind of property and counts properties of the others in its cluster, as proper names and proper nouns do, which is why they inform one another. Expressive classification connects standalone and prenominal *damn* across the category boundary; conative *sh* belongs to the

category's core without requiring evaluative stance. The distinction between stance and depiction adds another useful comparison of contribution.

The same approach distinguishes coexistence from competition. Expressive commonality leaves the rival category analyses of complement-taking *damn* unresolved. The relevant question is what each assignment warrants expecting about the identified use, and where another classification improves or changes that expectation. Inquiry-relative categories organize overlapping routes of inference through linguistic expressions, their constructional relations, and their realizations. Their reach depends on the supported associations, rather than on the disciplinary origin of the classification.

Acknowledgements

This paper reanalyses material I compiled for the Wikipedia article "English interjections". The archived data and analysis code accompany the linked evidence supplement.

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